The Care Situation You Already Have

A short guide for families planning ahead.

A ride to the doctor. A hand with the bills. A call every Wednesday night. Nobody ever decided any of it, and nobody calls it care. Put together, it is the arrangement Mom's week runs on, even though she is still largely independent.

This guide explains what a family's care situation is and what belongs in a written picture of it. It describes. It doesn't judge how Mom is doing, and it doesn't suggest that anything should change.

Begin while the week is quiet

There's no decision on the table, and that makes this the easy time to talk.

The Family Caregiver Alliance's advice to brothers and sisters is plain: if there's no emergency, allow some time to get everyone on the same page. [1]

Start with Mom. AARP's planning guide says a family's plan should never be made without the participation, knowledge and consent of the person it's about. It also says you may be surprised to find she has been meaning to have the talk too. [2]

- Invite, don't announce. “Walk me through a normal week” opens a conversation. “We're getting things organized” tends to close one.
- Write down the help that already exists before talking about anything else.
- Agree on a sensible reason to look at the picture again: a date, or a change in her routine or in who helps.

Describe the week as it is

A word like “independent” or “fine” means something different to each person who says it. A typical day is harder to misread: what her mornings look like, the middle of the day, the evening, and overnight. Describing the day part by part is the roadmap's own method.

For a list of what to ask about, the federal long-term care glossary names the activities that living independently involves: light housework, preparing meals, taking medication, shopping, using the telephone, managing money, taking care of pets and getting around the community. Treat it as a list of topics for a conversation. It isn't a test. [3]

- Keep what is true today apart from what anyone thinks should change. This page holds only the first.
- If a routine is different from last year, write what changed and when, and stop there.

Map the people and the work

Caregiving, the Family Caregiver Alliance says, often creeps up on you. It starts with a load of laundry or a ride to an appointment, and gradually you are doing more. No wonder nobody has made a list. [4]

You're in wide company. A 2025 report from the National Alliance for Caregiving and AARP counts 63 million family caregivers, one in every four adults, and they include siblings, friends and neighbors. [5]

The Family Caregiver Alliance suggests that each helper list what they do, for their own clarity and for relatives who may not be aware of it. AARP adds that most families have a point person who keeps things moving, often simply because they live nearby. [4] [2]

- For each person, write what they actually do and how often. It may not match what the family assumes.
- Note who keeps track of the information: the appointments, the phone numbers, who said what.

Build the starting summary

Expect the family's versions to differ. Parents often tell their kids different things about how they're doing, the Family Caregiver Alliance notes, and each person's outlook is bound to be different. Its advice is to pool your information. [1]

The roadmap adds two habits of its own. When two accounts differ, keep both, with a name beside each. Where nobody knows, write “not yet known” instead of a guess.

Then put it on one page. AARP says of a family's plan that it doesn't have to be extensive or fancy, and that holds for this page too. The CDC suggests going back to a written care plan every year, or sooner after a change in health or medicines, and a family's page can borrow that rhythm. [2] [6]

That page is also what you would bring to a review with your care consultant: what's known, what's seen differently, and what's still open.

What this means for your family

- Your family already has a care situation. It's the rides, the calls and the small jobs, and it can be written down in a calm week.
- The page describes Mom's week as it is. It doesn't measure her, and it doesn't call for anything to change.
- When relatives describe things differently, that is information. Keep both versions.
- Questions about her health go to her doctor. What a written picture means for care is for a professional who assesses her.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't say how Mom is managing, whether she needs more help or less, or what the family should decide. The quoted advice and the figure come from the sources below. The method (a typical day, both versions kept, “not yet known”) is the roadmap's own.

Ready for the next step?

You can see the care situation your family already has, and you know what belongs on the page. The care interview asks about each part of Mom's daily life in turn, including the areas no one has thought to mention, and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

1. Family Caregiver Alliance, Caregiving with Your Siblings
2. AARP, Prepare to Care: A Planning Guide for Families
3. Administration for Community Living (LongTermCare.gov), Glossary
4. Family Caregiver Alliance, Caregiving 101: On Being a Caregiver
5. National Alliance for Caregiving and AARP, Caregiving in the US 2025: Report Highlights & Key Messages
6. Centers for Disease Control and Prevention, Steps for Creating and Maintaining a Care Plan